

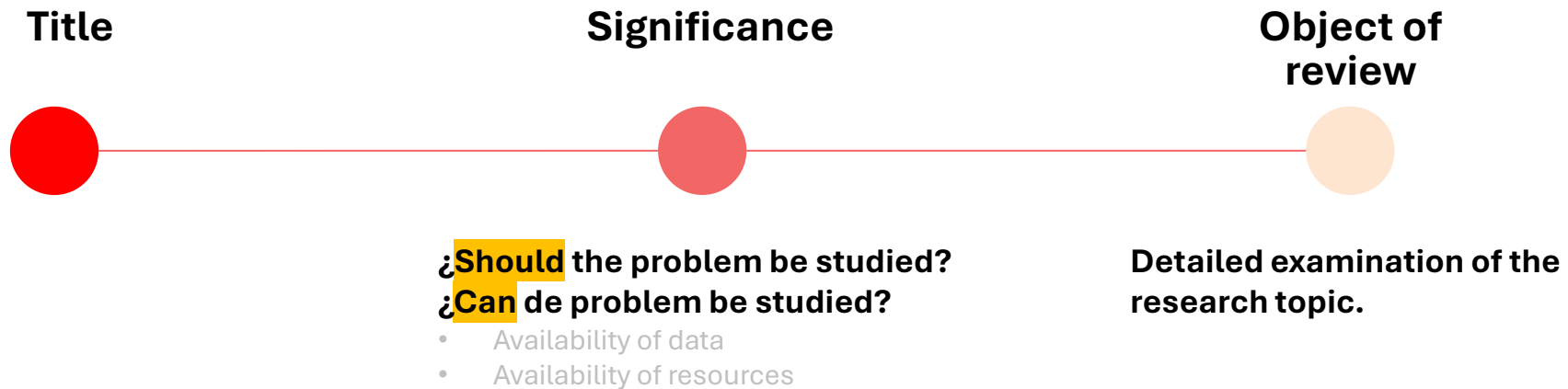
Literature Review



- Explain the reasons for conducting a literature review to justify its use.
- Organise a literature review consistent with a quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods approach.
- Describe the steps typically taken when carrying out a literature review. Identify the types of terms that need to be defined in an academic research report.

Steps in the process of developing a research proposal

The topic (of the research) is the subject or matter proposed for study. **It is the central idea to learn about or explore in a study.**



Steps in the process of developing a research proposal

Should the topic be studied?

This is the case when the topic contributes to the body of research knowledge in the available literature.

- 1. Replicate previous studies**
- 2. Give voice to underrepresented groups or individuals**
- 3. Address social justice or transform researchers' ideas and beliefs**

How does this project contribute to the literature?

Steps in the process of developing a research proposal

Should the topic be studied?

This is the case when the topic contributes to the body of research knowledge in the available literature.

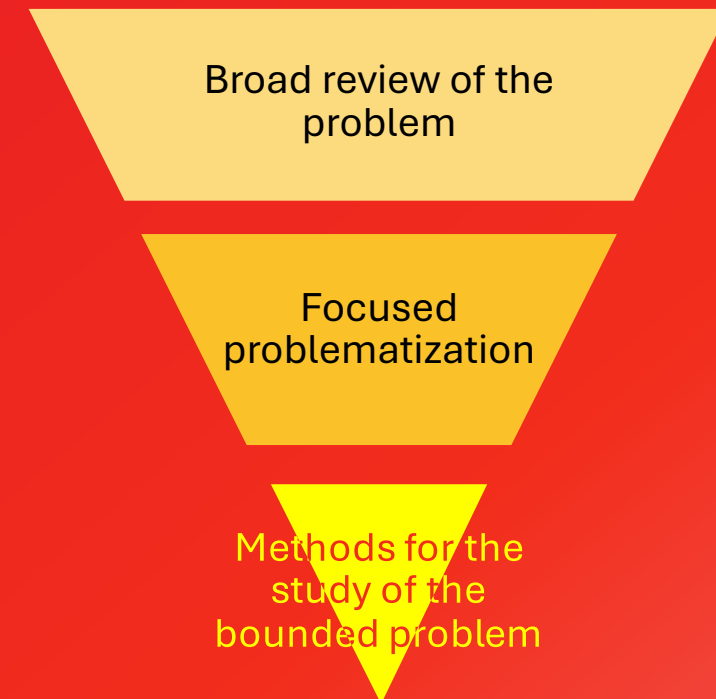
- 1. Replicate previous studies**
- 2. Give voice to underrepresented groups or individuals**
- 3. Address social justice or transform researchers' ideas and beliefs**

How does this project contribute to the literature?

-  Studying an unusual location
-  Examining a new/unusual group of participants
-  Taking an unexpected perspective that challenges expectations in the field
-  Providing novel means of data collection
-  Presenting results in new ways
-  Studying a timely or current issue

Purpose of a Literature Review

- 1.** Share with the reader the results of other studies that are **closely related to the topic being investigated.**
- 2.** Relate the study to the existing literature, **filling gaps and expanding on previous studies.**
- 3.** **Provide a framework to establish the importance of the study** and a point of reference to compare the results with other findings.



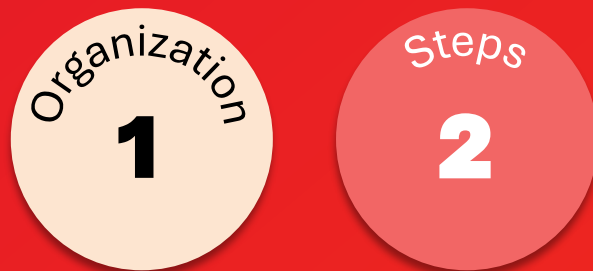
Purpose of a Literature Review

A literature review **means locating and summarizing studies on a topic**

These are often research studies, but they may also include:

- Conceptual articles
- Opinion pieces that provide frameworks for thinking about the

There is no single way to conduct a literature review, but in academia the process is carried out systematically to capture, evaluate, and summarize the literature.



Organization of the Literature Review

General Forms

From a general perspective, the literature review **consists of information that supplements the introduction of the study.** Alternatively, it may have its own section within the document.”

Qualitative Structure

The literature is used to learn from participants without imposing questions from the researcher’s perspective. Qualitative studies are exploratory; there is usually little prior research on the topic or population, so the focus is on listening to and understanding participants.

Quantitative Structure

It serves to introduce the problem, detail the existing literature, and **present theories that explain expected relationships, justifying their relevance to the study, as well as to support the study’s hypotheses.**

Mixed-Methods Structure

The researcher adopts a qualitative or quantitative approach to the literature depending on the strategy employed. For example, in sequential approaches, **the literature is presented in each phase according to the method applied in that stage.**

Organization of the Literature Review

General Forms

From a general perspective, the literature review consists of information that supplements the introduction of the study. Alternatively, it may have its own section within the document.

1. Integrating methods and findings from other studies

2. Critiquing methods and findings from other studies

3. Connecting themes or areas

4. Identifying a central problem within the field of knowledge

Organization of the Literature Review

Qualitative Structure

Qualitative studies are exploratory; there is usually little prior literature on the topic or population, so the focus is on listening to and understanding participants.

Use of the Literature	Criteria	Examples
Framing the problem in the introduction of the study	There must be some literature available	Used in all types of qualitative studies
Different section from the introduction	Post-positivist traditional approach to literature reviews	Studies with a quantitative approach
Presented at the end of the document to compare the study's findings	Does not guide or direct the study. It supports the work after identifying patterns or categories	Studies with a qualitative approach



Organization of the Literature Review

Quantitative Structure

Use in the introduction

Developed at the beginning of the study to provide direction for the research questions and hypotheses.

Use in a separate section

Developed at the beginning of the study to provide direction for the research questions and hypotheses.

Use at the end

Comparison of the study's results with the findings of the existing literature.

Step	Contents
Introduction	Description of the contents of the review (subsections).
Dependent Variable	Review of studies related to the dependent variable.
Independent Variable	Review of studies related to the independent variable (with subsections if there are multiple ones).
Variable Relationships	This section should be relatively short and contain studies that are extremely related to the proposed study topic.
Summary	Presents the most important studies and suggests the reason for investigating the topic and how the research seeks to contribute to that need.



Organization of the Literature Review

Mixed-methods Structure

A qualitative or quantitative approach to the literature is used depending on the type of strategy employed.

Quantitative start: include a review that helps establish justification for the research questions or hypotheses.

Qualitative start: the literature is substantially reduced, incorporate it at the end of the study, adopting an inductive approach.

In a sequential approach, the literature is presented in each phase according to the method used. The literature used must be consistent with the primary design type and with the most prevalent qualitative or quantitative approach in the design.



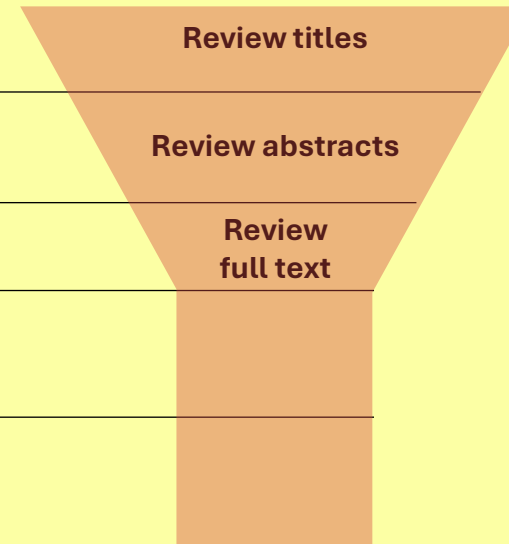
(Suggested) steps for a literature review

Planning the review

- 1.** Formulate the problem
- 2.** Develop and validate the review protocol

Conducting the review

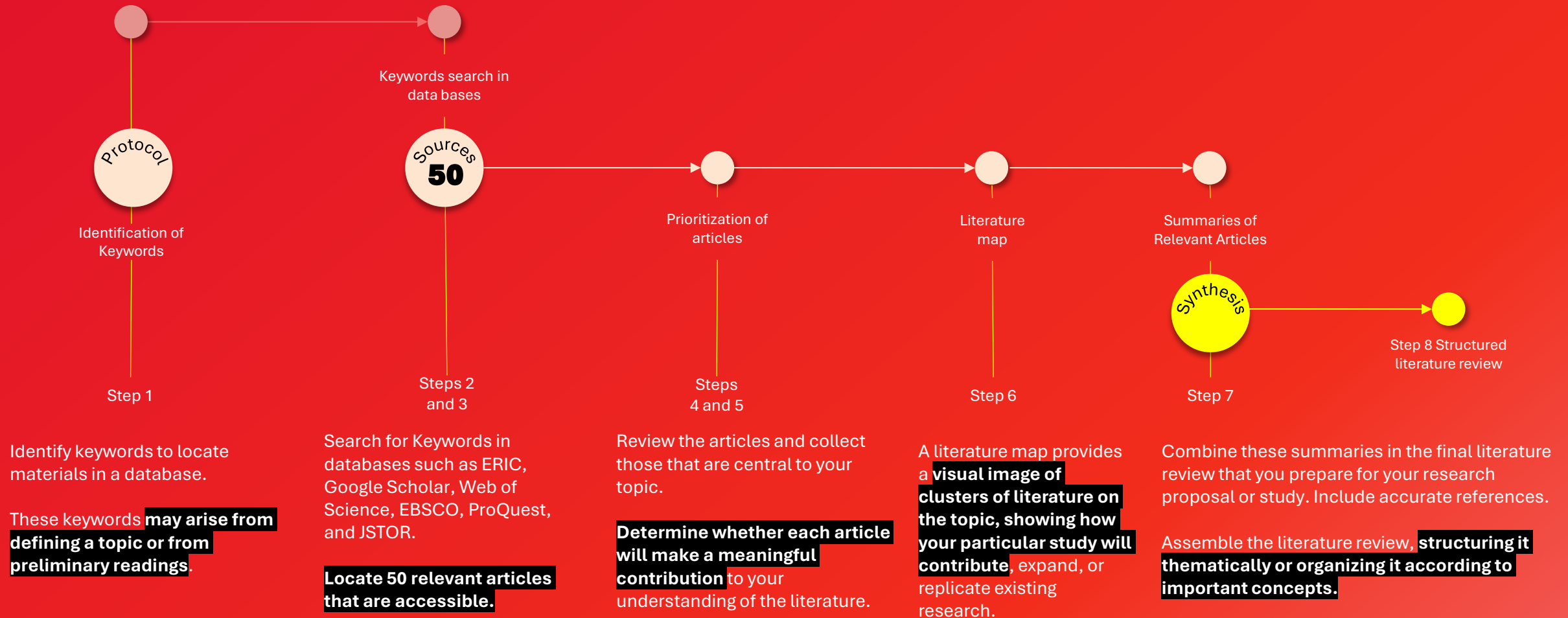
- 3.** Search the literature
- 4.** Screen for inclusion
- 5.** Assess quality
- 6.** Extract data
- 7.** Synthesize data



Report findings

- 8.** Report findings

(Suggested) steps for a literature review



Step 1

Review protocol

The review protocol is comparable to a research design in social science studies

It is a preset plan that specifies the methods utilized in conducting the review

- **It reduces the possibility of research bias** in data selection and analysis .
- **It increases the reliability of the review** because others can use the same protocol cross-check and verification.

- ✓ The purpose of the study
- ✓ Research questions
- ✓ Inclusion criteria
- ✓ Search strategies
- ✓ Quality assessment criteria and screening procedures
- ✓ Strategies for data extraction, synthesis, and reporting

Steps 2 and 3 Literature Search

Use both the free online literature databases and those **available through Externado's online resources.**

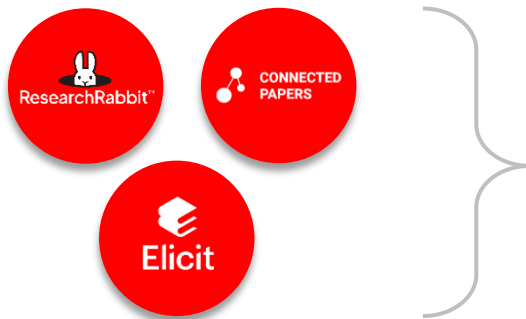


- 1.** Use term guides to locate your articles, **such as a thesaurus**, when available.
- 2.** Conduct a **preliminary search using online thesaurus descriptors** and by locating a journal article or document on a topic.
- 3.** Then look closely at the **descriptors used in this article and document and** perform another search using those terms.

Steps 2 and 3

Literature Search

Backward and forward search by author or document



When searching for the publications of key authors who contribute to the body of work, it is possible to identify relevant studies.

- A search through the authors' CVs, Google Scholar pages, and publications listed in researcher networks such as ResearchGate.net are good ways to locate their other publications.
- You can also identify cross-references in relevant works for each area by using seed-based search tools.

Steps 4 and 5

Articles prioritization and evaluation

1. What types of literature should be reviewed, and in what order of priority?

If the topic is unfamiliar: broad literature syntheses, such as encyclopedia entries, meta-analyses, reviews, or series of summaries.

Relevance of journals and scientific publications: review the most recent journal issues and then work backward. Follow the references at the end of the articles to locate more sources.

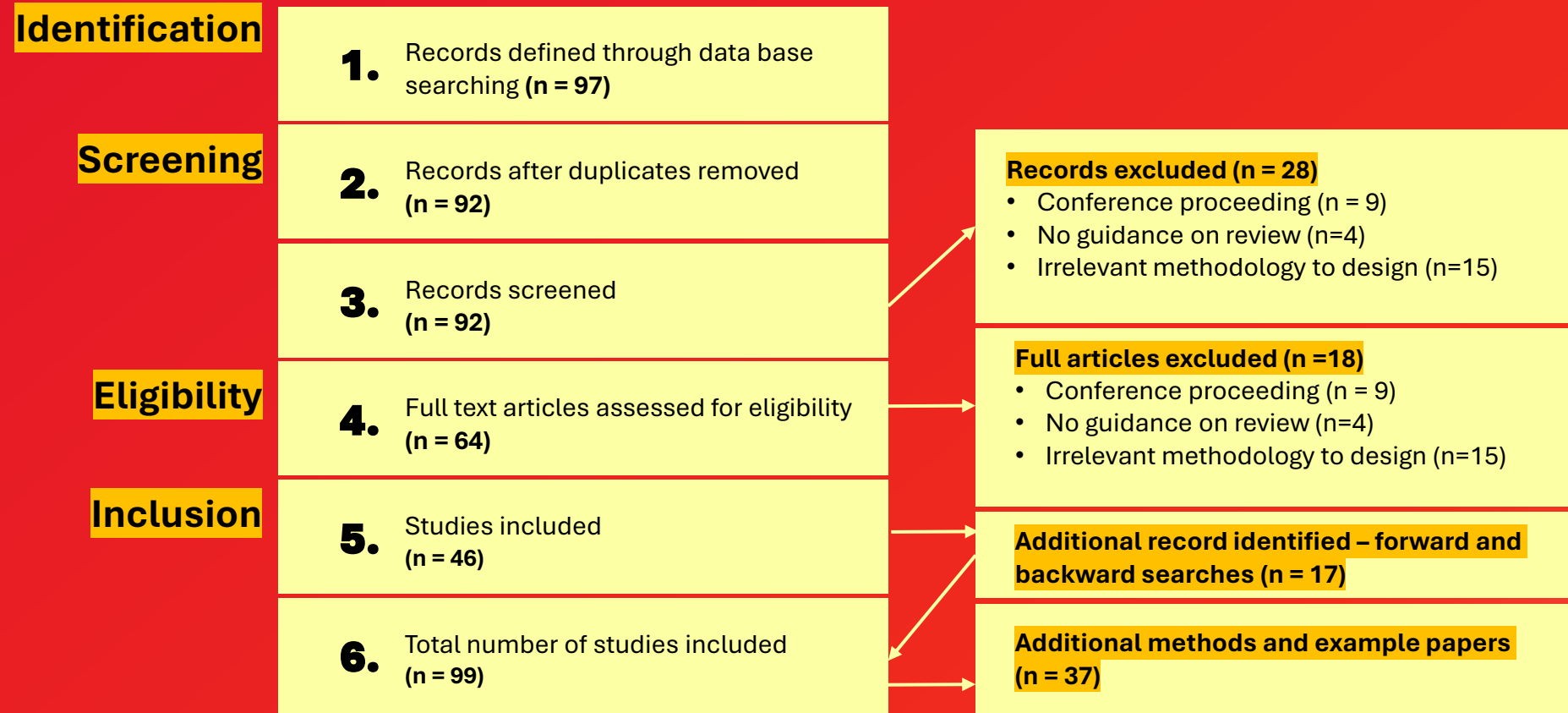
- Review of books and book chapters.
- Review of conference papers and presentations.

2. Quality evaluation

- **Journals:** look for articles published in peer-reviewed journals. These are journals with an editorial board.
- **Books:** look for publishers with recognized names and years of service.
- **Conference papers:** they may provide useful and high-quality information if the work is included as a presentation in a recent conference.

Steps 4 and 5

Articles prioritization and evaluation



Steps 6

Literature map

A literature map enables researchers to organise the literature review.

- It helps researchers **understand how the proposed study adds** to, expands upon, or replicates existing research.
- In positivistic approaches it helps to **map theoretical relationships** between constructs.

1. Hierarchical

Presenting the literature from the **top down**, ending with the proposed study at the bottom.

2. Flow-based

Understands the literature from **left to right**, with the far-right section advancing towards a proposed study.

3. Set-based

Circles represent a body of literature, and the intersection of circles indicates areas where further research is needed.

Steps 6

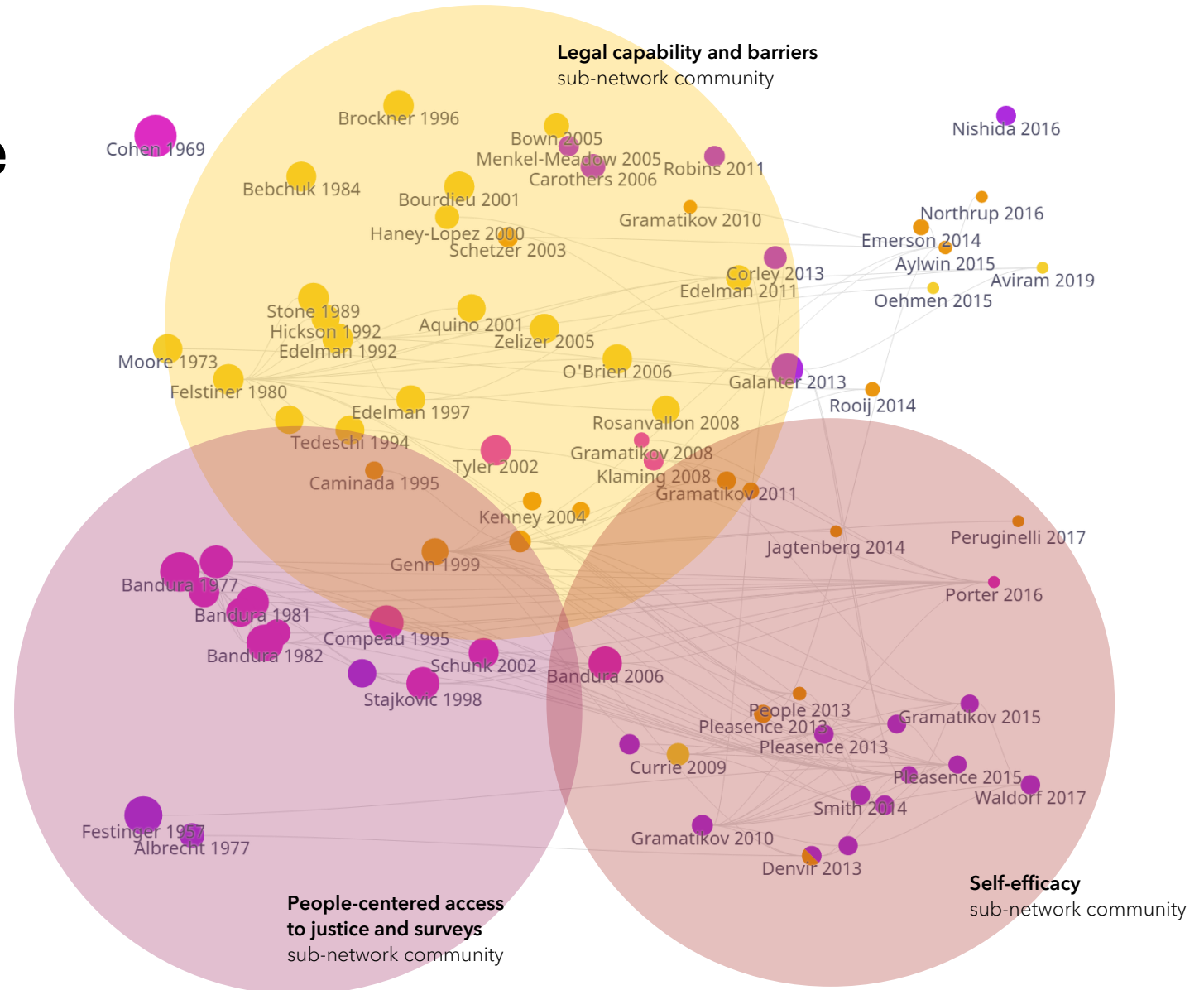
Literature map

Set based example

Recent literature on access to justice brings together two main perspectives.

- The first focuses on identifying **legal needs through person-centred accounts**, typically using large-scale household surveys.
- The second centres on **legal capability**, understood as a fundamental attribute that shapes individuals' ability to engage effectively with the justice system.

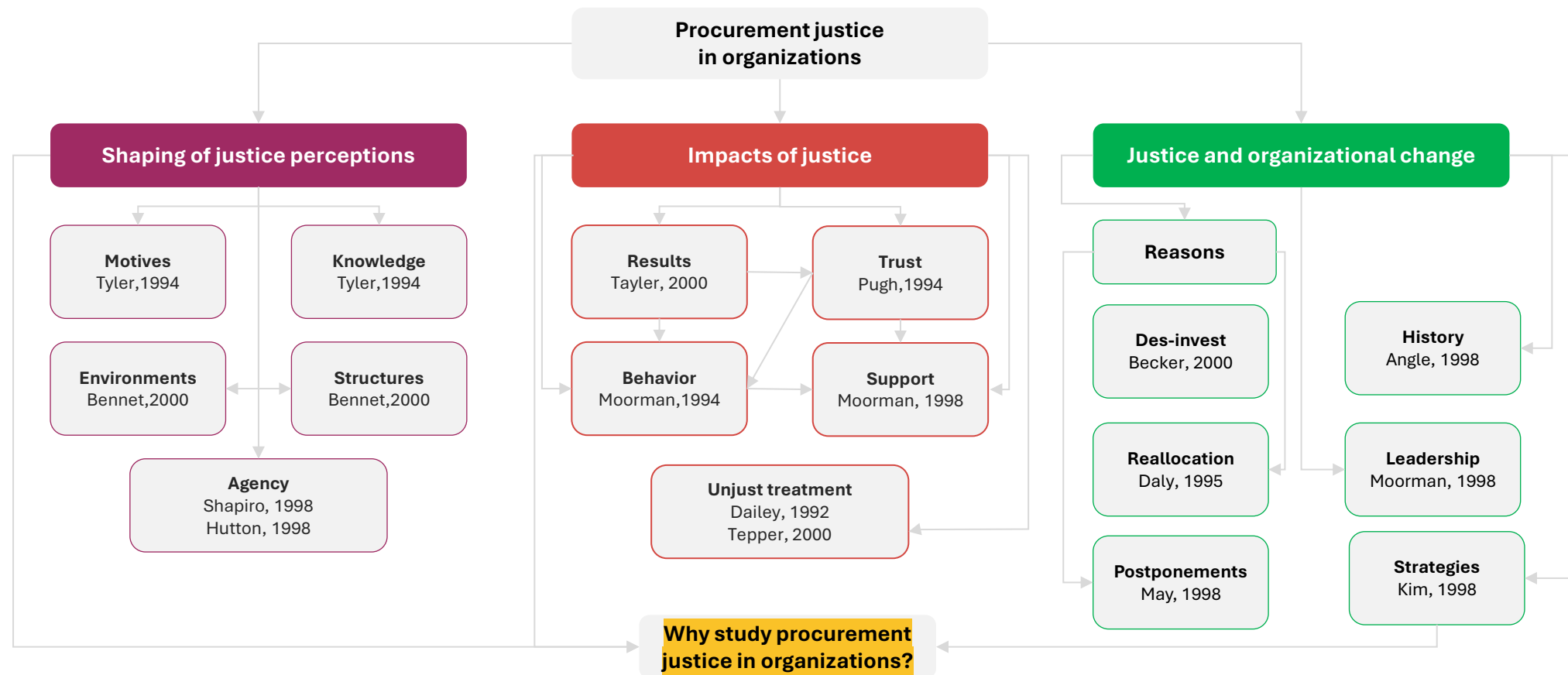
- Self-efficacy literature
- People centered access to justice literature
- Legal capability and barriers literature
- Surveys and methods literature



Steps 6

Literature map

Hierarchical example



Use of theory

The scientific method



Dr Evelyn Behar and Dr Nicole Cain **discuss the steps involved in planning and conducting research.**

The steps of the scientific method help to **strengthen the research process and enhance the researcher's ability to draw sound conclusions from it.**

Behar and Cain address the selection of a research topic, the design of a study, and the procedures required to carry out the research.